

Candidate Questionnaire

Please limit each response to approximately 200 words.

Candidate Name: Dr. Tamara Mattison

1. Vision for Technology in Education

What role should technology play in K-12 education, and how should that role differ across elementary, middle, and high school grade levels?

Technology should serve learning—not to replace it! My position is neither “more technology” nor “less technology.” It is technology with purpose: Saint Paul Public Schools should use technology when it demonstrably strengthens learning, expands opportunity, supports teachers, engages families, or improves accessibility—but it should not allow devices, software, or artificial intelligence to replace strong teaching, deep reading, independent thinking, human relationships, or fiscal discipline.

2. Student Devices and Classroom Learning

What is your perspective on the use of district-issued 1:1 devices (iPads) in Saint Paul Public Schools? What changes, if any, would you like to see in current practices (e.g., eliminate 1:1 devices for some or all grade levels, establish formal limits on screen time, move from iPads to Chromebooks, etc.)?

Leadership that runs D.E.E.P. is my main theme!!!

Deliver Academic Excellence: Technology purchases should be judged primarily by whether they improve teaching and measurable student learning—not by novelty, vendor promises, or usage statistics.

Empower Student Voice: Students should help evaluate technology, AI rules, digital citizenship, accessibility, distraction, and the quality of their digital learning experiences.

Engage Families: Families need multilingual information, meaningful privacy protections, digital-literacy support, and a voice in decisions about screen time, AI, home connectivity, and student data.

Prioritize Student Well-Being: SPPS should distinguish instructional technology from digital distraction. Age-appropriate screen use, phone boundaries, cybersecurity, online safety, cyberbullying prevention, and human connection are educational issues as well as technology issues.

3. Attention, Engagement, and Student Well-Being

How should the district balance the educational benefits of technology with concerns related to student attention, engagement in learning, social development, mental health, and overall well-being?

I'm not anti-technology, and I'm not for technology just because it's new. SPPS has already made a major investment in devices and digital learning. My question as a Board member would be: Is it helping children read, do math, think critically and prepare for their future? If the evidence says yes, let's invest. If it distracts students, compromises privacy or doesn't produce results, we need the courage to change course.

4. Evidence and Learning Outcomes

What evidence or metrics would you want to see to determine whether classroom technology is improving student learning and educational outcomes and whether there is sufficient return on the district's investment?

SPPS has built valuable technology infrastructure, and every student having access to instructional technology is an equity strength. My argument is that after investing heavily in access, the next question must be outcomes. I want us to keep the technology that helps students and teachers while making sure devices don't replace books, handwriting, conversation, laboratories or great teaching. This is not about taking technology away. It's about getting more educational value from what we already have."

SPPS reports nearly 40,000 iPads and universal school-day student access, so the factual premise of this response is strong. If 96% of SPPS students say iPads help them learn, why are you questioning technology?

I think 96% positive student feedback is encouraging, and student voice matters to me. But good governance means using more than one measure. I want student feedback, teacher feedback, usage data and academic outcomes. A child can enjoy a tool and find it helpful, while the Board still has a responsibility to ask whether a multimillion-dollar system is improving reading, math and critical thinking. My position is not to question students. It's to listen to them and then look at the complete evidence.

5. Family and Community Engagement

What role should parents, families, students, and educators play in shaping district technology policies and practices? Parents shouldn't be asked for blind trust. They should be given transparency. SPPS already reviews apps, uses vendor contracts and data-sharing agreements, and limits device-location access. I would build on that by publishing a plain-language vendor privacy inventory: what information each company receives, why it receives it, how long it keeps it, whether AI is involved, when the contract expires and what happens to the data afterward. With children's information, privacy should be designed into the purchase—not discussed after the contract is signed.

SPPS's current privacy and app-review systems provide the foundation for that proposal.

I'm pro-child, pro-teacher and pro-learning. Sometimes technology is the best tool. Sometimes a book is. Sometimes a conversation is. The job of the School Board is to know the difference—and to make sure taxpayers are paying for results, not simply products.

6. Accountability and Oversight

As a School Board member, how would you evaluate progress on technology-related goals and hold district leadership accountable for implementation, budget, and outcomes? A notable strength is SPPS's privacy architecture. The district says every digital tool accessing student data must be approved for content quality and privacy; external learning-management companies enter contracts and data-sharing agreements; authentication is managed through district systems; location access is tightly controlled; and general staff do not have device-location access. Those are meaningful protections.

But the Board should distinguish policy on paper from assurance in practice. A mature governance system should be able to answer publicly: Which vendors possess student data? Which fields? For what purpose? For how long? Is the vendor permitted to train an AI model on those records? What happens at contract termination? Has an independent assessment been completed? What did each platform cost? How many students and teachers used it? An annual review should be required to hold district leadership accountable.

7. Artificial Intelligence

As artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies become increasingly available to students and educators, what principles should guide district decisions about their use? Do you support a moratorium on generative AI in Saint Paul Public Schools while the district undertakes a full review? Banning students from understanding AI would not prepare them for the world they're entering. But unrestricted use isn't education either. I want students to learn how to question AI, verify it, identify bias, protect their privacy and disclose when they've used it. AI should help students think—not do their thinking for them. For assessments where we need to know what a child knows, students also have to demonstrate independent work.

That position is aligned with SPPS's current AI principles and with Stanford's warning that the rigorous K–12 evidence base remains limited.

8. Looking Ahead

If elected, what would be your highest priority related to technology use in Saint Paul Public Schools during your first term? My highest priority would be delivering academic excellence by strengthening literacy, math, and career readiness. Investing in mental health safety, and supportive school environments. Closing opportunity gaps with measurable, results-driven action. Ensuring families are heard, informed, and actively involved.

Thank you for your participation. Please return to intentionaltechnologysaintpaul@gmail.com by September 25, 2026.